

A date with destiny

An inspired **Dhakshineswar Suresh** helps India pull off a thrilling 3-2 upset over the Netherlands to reach the Davis Cup Qualifiers second round.

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When the Davis Cup Qualifiers first-round draw was announced last year and India was pitted against the Netherlands, supporters could have been forgiven for thinking there wasn't much chance of victory. **The Dutch were, after all, ranked in the top 10, were runners-up in 2024, and had two accomplished singles players in Tallon Griekspoor and Botic van de Zandschulp.**

Then, in the weeks leading up to the tie, when it emerged that the duo would not be travelling to Bengaluru for the contest, India's hopes brightened. Even as its own top-ranked singles player Sumit Nagal had suffered a muscle tear in his hip and was fighting to be fit, the faithful sensed an upset. That Rohan Bopanna, with truckloads of experience and sustained excellence at the elite level, had retired was acknowledged but not fretted over.

On Sunday, under the glitzy night sky of the Garden City, those dreams came true when India beat the Netherlands by a thrilling 3-2 margin to punch its ticket to the Davis Cup Qualifiers second round. This September, captain Rohit Rajpal and his band of merry men



will take on South Korea. A victory will earn India a spot in the eight-team Davis Cup Finals, the highest stage in the iconic competition of which India is a three-time finalist.

The man who scripted this giant Indian leap was 25-year-old Dhakshineswar Suresh. Ranked 465 in the ATP rankings, the Tamil Nadu lad won both his singles matches and also combined with Yuki Bhambri to clinch the crucial doubles rubber.



Not since Leander Paes in 2004 had someone managed the feat of winning three matches in a single tie for India in Davis Cup.